

The Fast Chosen for Jesus

Let us open where we left off, because these are definitely the main texts for teaching on fasting. Go to Isaiah 58, and we will follow that with Matthew 4 and Luke 4.

For years, every time I taught on fasting I included Isaiah 58. But I also knew there had to be a difference between fasting under the old covenant and fasting in the covenant of our sonship and inheritance. Old Testament saints were spiritually dead, unregenerated in spirit, waiting through those four thousand years for the dispensation when Jesus would come, the promise to Abraham would be fulfilled, and we would become part of his seed.

God had to deal with spiritually dead men differently than He deals with us as sons. He would hardly let me into the Old Testament until I understood the New Testament all the way into sonship and inheritance. Now the Old Testament is opening up to me. Even the genealogies have begun to pour back out of my spirit.

But I could not rightly use Old Testament examples until I understood the covenant we are in. There is a vast difference between them and us, even in worship, and there is a vast difference in how we must understand fasting.

Then I saw it: Isaiah 58 is the fast God chose for Jesus. It is the fast He fulfilled in Matthew 4 and Luke 4. If it was the fast chosen for Jesus, then it is also the fast chosen for us.

Isaiah 58 says:

Is it such a fast that I have chosen? A day for a man to afflict his soul? Is it to bow down his head as a bulrush, and to spread sackcloth and ashes under him? Wilt thou call this a fast, and an acceptable day to the Lord?

Is not this the fast that I have chosen? To loose the bands of wickedness, to undo the heavy burdens, to let the oppressed go free, and that ye break every yoke?

Is it not to deal thy bread to the hungry, and that thou bring the poor that are cast out to thy house? When thou seest the naked, that thou cover him; and that thou hide not thyself from thine own flesh?

Now run to Isaiah 61 and you will hear the same language. This is the prophecy Jesus read when He walked into the synagogue and they gave Him the book of Isaiah:

The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me; because the Lord hath anointed me to preach good tidings unto the meek...

He preached the acceptable year of the Lord. Everyone knew He was talking about Jubilee, the fiftieth year, when captives were set free and debts were canceled. Jesus is the Jubilee.

Isaiah 58 and Isaiah 61 are speaking the same kind of language: loose the bands of wickedness, break every yoke, proclaim liberty to captives, open the prison to them that are bound. This was His text when He came out of the wilderness after the forty-day fast.

Satan met Jesus in the wilderness because he knew Jesus was standing at the door of Jubilee. He had to stop Him.

If you want to understand something of what happened in the Garden of Eden, look at the temptation of the last Adam. Adam was the accountable one in the fall of the human race. The temptation that came against Jesus must have been close to the temptation that brought the first Adam down.

Jesus fasted because He was getting His flesh ready for the temptation that would be presented to Him. Thank God, He prevailed.

This is the fast God chose for Jesus. And because Jesus is our pattern and our substitute, this same fast has been chosen for us.

The day you decide to fast is the day you decide to stop hiding from your own flesh.

Fasting is death to indifference and complacency. Whatever is in you that does not care about the naked, the hungry, the cast out, the lost, the bound, the oppressed, and the people going to hell while you sit in church and live in pleasure, fasting brings that thing into the light.

Whether you enter a series of fasts or one of those long prophet's fasts, the old man walks into the closet with you and locks the door behind him. Before it is over, he may become your least favorite person. Nevertheless, you are going to face him.

Fasting executes a positional truth of death that Jesus provided when you were born again:

 | The Spirit is life because of righteousness; but the body is dead because of sin.

This is why fasting does not do the same thing for Gandhi, Buddha, or people in false religions. They have no positional truth in Christ to execute. But when a believer fasts, the flesh is being brought under the verdict God has already spoken over it.

The day you decide to pray in tongues is the day you walk into the classroom of the Holy Spirit. That well-dressed Gentleman at the chalkboard begins teaching you what He knows. He bypasses your natural mind, goes straight for your spirit, and says, "Let Me originate the prayer."

The day you decide to fast in any measure is the day you decide to stop hiding from your own flesh.

That is why I like the combination Jesus gave us:

 | This kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting.

Prayer and fasting are the power twins. Together they build you up and bring the flesh down.

God is subtle. Sometimes He is almost sneaky. He gives you a language to pray in, and you do not even know what you are praying. You think you are praying about one thing while He is praying through you about something else. When I first began fasting and praying in tongues, if you had asked me what needed to change, my list would have been very different from His. I thought I needed material things to prove I had faith. His list was love, faithfulness, peace, and purity.

When you pray in tongues, your spirit is built up above the problem. When you fast, your flesh is pressed down beneath it. Then your eyes open, and you see through God's eyes: "Oh my God, is that me?" Yes, that is you. Cruelty, unforgiveness, torment, strife, and hardness come into view.

When your spirit rises to the occasion, you begin to hate what God hates. Now God has something to work with. When you loved those works of the flesh and did not care who they hurt, your spirit was weak. But when prayer and fasting make you hate that indifference as much as He does, faith is present for Him to move it out of your life.

You did not move God. You moved yourself into position to receive from Him.

No devil will be able to defile or defy you when this authority develops. You will say, "Come out," and when the devil says, "I am not coming out," you will answer, "I did not ask you. It was not a request."

That same authority develops toward disease. But you will not walk in that kind of faith while you remain indifferent. God is moved by compassion. If hundreds of children can be dying and suffering and that does not move you, then you need to give Him something to work with.

You may start fasting and praying while you are still quite carnal. But if you keep going, you will end up hating everything in you that does not care. Then God says, "Good. Now you hate it as much as I do. Now you are giving Me faith to put it to death."

Matthew 4 begins:

Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil.

That verse used to bother me. I would skip over it and go to the parts about moving mountains. In the Lord's Prayer Jesus taught us to pray, "Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil." Yet here He Himself is led by the Spirit into the wilderness for the purpose of being tempted by the devil.

Why was it for Him and not for us?

Because this was the beginning of His great work of identification and substitution. He was led into the wilderness as our substitute, in our place, to be tempted by the devil. Satan had to throw the worst he had at Him. Jesus had to stand under it, shut him down, and then turn to us and say:

Behold, I give unto you power over all the power of the enemy.

He won that standing and then gave it to us by grace. That is why His standing is enough.

If you tell a devil to come out and he refuses, do what Jesus said in Matthew 17: fast. Fasting does not earn the authority. It brings the flesh down so the authority He gave you can come forward.

After Jesus had fasted forty days and forty nights, He was hungry. I believe He likely drank water, because after forty days without water a person would want water before food.

The tempter came and said:

If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread.

Jesus answered:

It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.

The temptation came on the level of the body. Satan tried to get Him to minister to His own flesh. Jesus refused. There is no need you have that God will not supply, but Jesus would not let the devil turn need into disobedience.

Then the devil took Him to the holy city and set Him on the pinnacle of the temple:

If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee...

Jesus answered:

It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.

This temptation struck the soul: the mind, will, intellect, and emotions. Satan tried to badger Him into acting on a misinterpretation of Scripture. Jesus knew what was written, but He would not tempt God.

You can imagine the pressure Satan brought to bear. It would have put any natural man into the lowest ward of an asylum. But Jesus stood, and Satan could not break Him in the soul.

Then Satan took Him to an exceeding high mountain and showed Him the kingdoms of the world and the glory of them:

All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me.

This temptation moved into the spirit realm. Satan took Him to the seat of his authority, where he rules over the religions and systems of this world through principalities, powers, rulers of darkness, and spiritual wickedness in high places.

Brother Dene Crane once described an encounter in which he thought Jesus was coming to him, but his spirit felt uneasy. When the figure came close, he discovered it was the devil appearing like Jesus. Satan tried to imitate the throne of God, with demonic beings parading as cherubim.

That is the realm Satan offered Jesus: world rulership, religious power, and exaltation. He has offered the same thing to others: "I will make you a little god. I will make this part of the world worship you. I will make you wealthy beyond what you can imagine."

Self-exaltation and the exaltation people give you can be as addictive as cocaine. More artists and ministers have sold out when they discovered they had a marketable gift and people wanted to make them into something. If money is what you lack to hold that sacred position, you will be tempted to sell anything to keep it.

This may have been the temptation that took Adam down: "You shall be as gods." But Jesus answered:

Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.

Then the devil left Him, and angels came and ministered to Him.

Luke 4 says that when the devil had ended all the temptation, he departed from Jesus for a season. He would come back later to try his ground again. But Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit into Galilee, and His fame went throughout the region.

Then He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. As His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day and stood up to read. They delivered to Him the book of Isaiah, and He found the place where it was written:

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor...

He read of healing the brokenhearted, preaching deliverance to captives, recovering sight to the blind, setting at liberty them that are bruised, and preaching the acceptable year of the Lord. He was announcing Jubilee.

This is the fast God chose for Jesus. He prepared Himself for that temptation by fasting His flesh. He shut the devil down in spirit, soul, and body. Then He turned around and gave us His standing.

When Jesus says, "Behold, I give you power over all the power of the enemy," it does not matter how strong the temptation seems. The devil is not stronger than the standing Jesus gave you.

But if you tell the devil to come out and he will not, try what Jesus said:

 This kind cometh not out but by prayer and fasting.

Fasting does not move God. If your life is being sealed off by the flesh, and God's grace cannot operate freely through an undernourished spirit being dragged around by the flesh, fasting drops that ceiling below the operation of the spirit. Then the grace Jesus gave you comes forward.

You cannot earn that authority. It is a free gift. Prayer and fasting do not purchase it; they release the positional truths that are already yours in Christ.

When the flesh drops beneath the operation of the spirit, go tell that devil to come out again. Why will he come out? Because the Holy Ghost will reach inside that person and make him come out.

Stand up and let us worship God again.